

1. Purpose & Scope

This playbook outlines how Meridian Analytics plans, executes, and monitors operational performance across Product, Engineering, Sales, Marketing, and Customer Success. It serves as the standard reference for:

- Quarterly planning and prioritization
- OKR (Objectives & Key Results) tracking
- Cross-functional alignment and meeting cadence
- Escalation of operational risks and blockers
- Headcount planning and resource allocation

The goal is to ensure alignment, accountability, and execution velocity across all teams.

2. Quarterly Planning Process

Overview

Meridian operates on a quarterly planning cycle (Q1–Q4), anchored in annual strategic priorities. Planning is led by Strategy & Ops in partnership with executive leadership.

Timeline (Standard 6-Week Cycle)

Week	Activity
Week -6 to -5	Executive strategy refresh (CEO, CRO, CPO, CTO)
Week -5 to -3	Department-level planning and draft OKRs
Week -3 to -2	Cross-functional alignment sessions
Week -2 to -1	Executive review and prioritization
Week -1	Final OKR sign-off and communication

Step-by-Step Process

1. Strategic Direction (Exec Team)

- Define 3–5 company-level priorities (e.g., AI roadmap, enterprise expansion)
- Set top-line targets (ARR, pipeline, retention, product milestones)

2. Department Planning

Each function drafts:

- 2–4 Objectives aligned to company priorities
- 3–5 Key Results per Objective
- Required resources (headcount, budget, tooling)

3. Cross-Functional Alignment

- Identify dependencies (e.g., Product ↔ Sales enablement)
- Resolve conflicts in prioritization
- Confirm sequencing and ownership

4. Executive Review

- Evaluate feasibility vs. impact
- De-scope or re-prioritize as needed
- Ensure company-wide alignment

5. Finalization & Rollout

- Publish OKRs in centralized system (e.g., Notion, Workboard)
- Conduct all-hands review
- Cascade OKRs to team and individual levels

Planning Principles

- Focus over breadth: Max 3–5 company objectives
- Measurable outcomes: Avoid vague or activity-based KRs
- Cross-functional ownership: Shared accountability for key initiatives
- Capacity realism: Plan within ~70–80% of available bandwidth

3. OKR Tracking Procedures

System of Record

- Primary tracking in: [OKR platform — e.g., Workboard / Notion]
- Weekly updates required for all active Key Results

Weekly Update Process

Owners: KR owners (typically Directors/Managers)

Each KR must include:

- Current progress (% or metric value)
- Status indicator:
- Green: On track
- Yellow: At risk
- Red: Off track
- Brief commentary:
- What changed this week
- Risks or blockers
- Support needed

Weekly OKR Review (Ops-Led)

Cadence: Weekly (30–45 min)

Participants: Strategy & Ops, Functional Leaders

Agenda:

1. Review red/yellow KRs
 2. Identify root causes (resourcing, dependencies, execution gaps)
 3. Assign actions and owners
 4. Escalate systemic issues if needed
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Monthly Business Review (MBR)

Cadence: Monthly (60–90 min)

Participants: Executive Team + Functional Leaders

Focus:

- Progress vs. quarterly targets
 - Key wins and misses
 - Forecast adjustments
 - Strategic risks
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End-of-Quarter Review

- Final KR scoring (0.0–1.0 scale recommended)
 - Retrospective:
 - What worked / didn't
 - Planning accuracy
 - Execution gaps
 - Inputs into next quarter planning cycle
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4. Cross-Functional Meeting Cadence

To maintain alignment without excessive overhead, Meridian follows a structured meeting rhythm:

Weekly Cadence

1. Executive Sync (60 min)

- Company-level metrics (ARR, pipeline, churn)
- Strategic blockers
- Major cross-functional decisions

2. GTM Sync (45 min)

- Sales, Marketing, Customer Success
- Pipeline health, campaigns, customer risks

3. Product & Engineering Sync (45–60 min)

- Roadmap progress
- Release updates
- Technical risks

4. Ops & Strategy Sync (30 min)

- OKR tracking
- Planning updates
- Operational bottlenecks

Bi-Weekly / Monthly Cadence

Cross-Functional Initiative Reviews (Bi-Weekly)

- Deep dives on major initiatives (e.g., AI feature launch)
- Track milestones, dependencies, risks

Customer Insights Review (Monthly)

- Feedback from Sales & CS
- Product implications
- Retention/churn analysis

Financial & Forecast Review (Monthly)

- Budget vs. actuals
- Hiring progress
- Revenue forecast updates

Meeting Principles

- Default to decision-oriented agendas
- Require pre-reads for complex topics
- Limit recurring meetings without clear outcomes
- Document decisions and action items centrally

5. Escalation Paths for Operational Issues

Definition of Escalation

An issue should be escalated when it:

- Blocks progress on a company-level OKR
- Impacts revenue, customer experience, or product delivery
- Cannot be resolved within a team within 48–72 hours

Escalation Levels

Level 1: Team-Level Resolution

- Owner attempts to resolve within function
- Timeline: <48 hours

Level 2: Cross-Functional Escalation

- Engage dependent teams (e.g., Product ↔ Sales)
- Coordinated via Ops or relevant leaders
- Timeline: <72 hours

Level 3: Executive Escalation

- Triggered when:
- Revenue impact > defined threshold
- Customer risk (e.g., churn of key account)
- Strategic initiative blocked
- Escalation path:
- Notify Strategy & Ops → escalate to Exec Sync or ad hoc meeting

Escalation Template (Required)

- Issue Summary:
- Impact (Revenue, Customer, Product):
- Root Cause (if known):
- Actions Taken:
- Decision Required:
- Owner:

Common Escalation Categories

- Product delivery delays
- Critical customer incidents
- Pipeline shortfalls
- Resource constraints (headcount or budget)
- Data or reporting inaccuracies

6. Headcount Planning Guidelines

Principles

- Align hiring with strategic priorities and OKRs
- Balance growth vs. efficiency
- Prioritize roles with direct revenue or product impact
- Maintain flexibility for mid-quarter adjustments

Annual & Quarterly Planning

Annual Planning

- Define target headcount by function
- Align with revenue and product roadmap goals
- Set hiring budget

Quarterly Adjustments

- Reallocate based on:
- Performance vs. plan
- Market conditions
- Strategic shifts

Headcount Request Process

All new roles must include:

- Role description and level
- Business justification:
- Which OKR(s) it supports
- Expected impact (revenue, efficiency, delivery)
- Urgency level (critical / important / optional)
- Time-to-productivity estimate

Approval Flow:

Hiring Manager → Functional Leader → Finance → Executive Approval

Prioritization Framework

Roles are evaluated based on:

1. Revenue Impact
 - Direct (e.g., Sales, Customer Success)
 - Indirect (e.g., Product, Engineering)
2. Strategic Alignment
 - Supports top company priorities
3. Capacity Constraints
 - Current team bandwidth and bottlenecks
4. ROI
 - Expected return vs. cost within 6–12 months

Hiring Guardrails

- Avoid over-hiring ahead of validated demand
- Maintain target revenue per employee benchmarks
- Sequence hiring with roadmap dependencies
- Use contractors/temporary resources where appropriate

7. Governance & Continuous Improvement

- Strategy & Ops owns this playbook and reviews it quarterly
- Feedback loops:
- Post-quarter retrospectives
- Leadership input
- Team-level feedback

Updates are communicated via:

- Internal documentation hub
- Quarterly all-hands
- Ops newsletters (if applicable)

8. Key Takeaways

- Quarterly planning drives alignment; OKRs drive execution
- Clear meeting cadence ensures cross-functional coordination
- Structured escalation prevents stalled execution
- Disciplined headcount planning supports sustainable growth

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